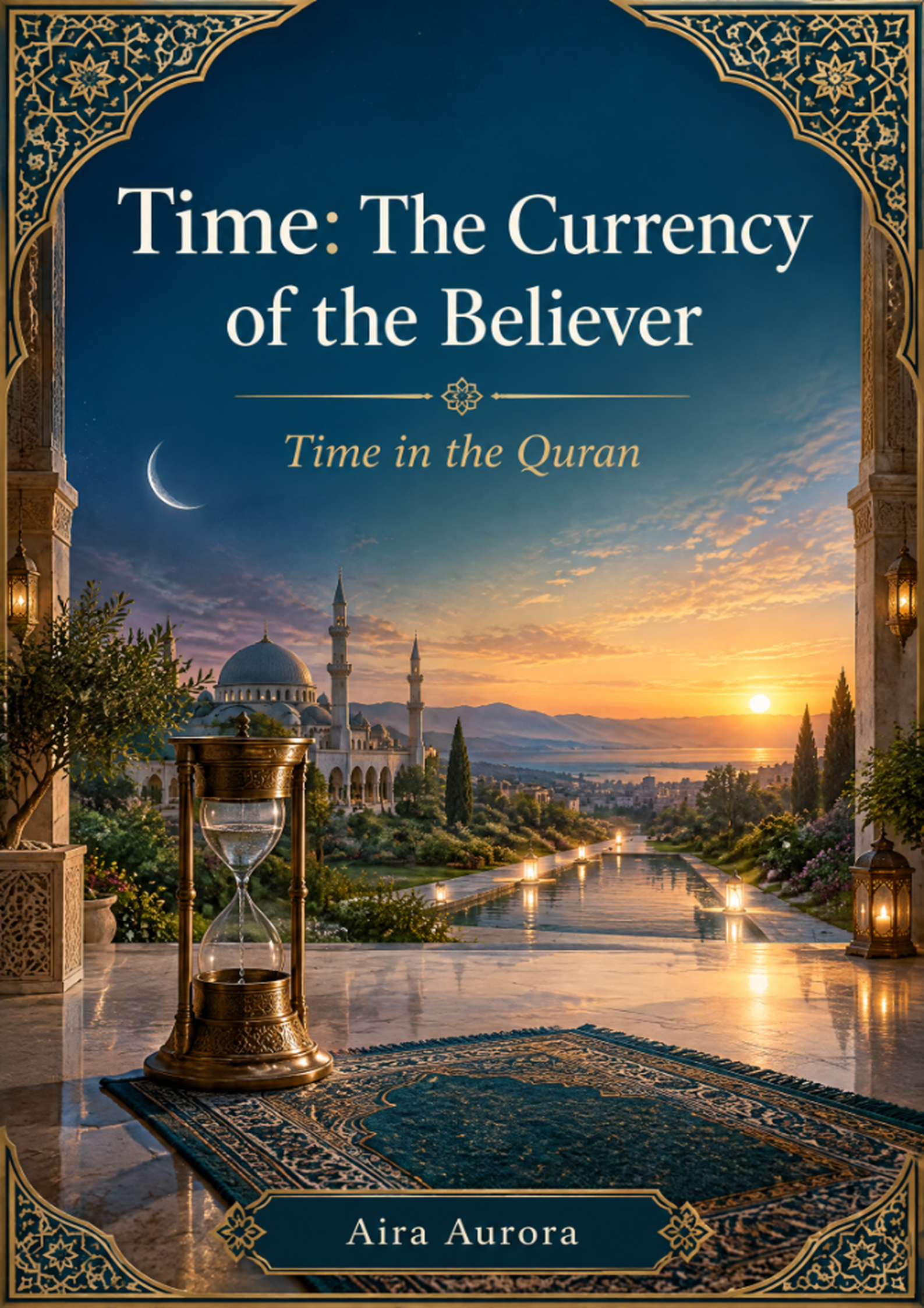
# Time: The Currency of the Believer

*Time in the Quran*



Aira Aurora

# DISCLAIMER

This book is an educational study of Time as presented in the Quran. The primary source is the Quran; where Hadith is referenced, it is drawn from established collections and clearly indicated. English translations of Quranic verses are interpretive and should be cross-referenced with the original Arabic text.

This work is a study and reflection, not a fatwa and not a substitute for formal Islamic education. Readers are encouraged to consult qualified scholars for religious rulings and guidance.

# INTRODUCTION

Time is the currency of the believer. The Quran says: "By time, indeed, mankind is in loss, except for those who have believed and done righteous deeds and advised each other to truth and advised each other to patience" (103:1-3). The surah - one of the shortest in the Quran - establishes time as the measure of human existence and the condition for salvation. The human being is in loss - measured by time - except for those who use their time for faith, righteous deeds, and mutual counsel. The surah is the Quran's most concentrated statement on the value of time, and it is the foundation of the Islamic approach to the management of the believer's most precious resource.

This book examines the Quranic perspective on time, exploring the key verses, the prophetic tradition, and the lessons that emerge from the Quranic framework for the believer's relationship with time. The Quran does not present time as an abstract philosophical concept but as the practical medium in which the human life unfolds and the divine test is administered. The time that is given to the human being is the time that will be accounted for, and the accounting is the reason that time is the currency - the currency that must be invested well, the currency that cannot be saved for later, and the currency that is spent whether the person uses it or wastes it. The book is part of the Life in the Quran sub-series of the NurOne master series by Aira Aurora, and it is the final book in the twelve-book Life sub-series. The approach is through the Quranic text, supplemented by authentic prophetic tradition, and avoids speculation beyond what the sources provide. The goal is to present the Quranic understanding of time in a way that is both accessible and profound, both practical and spiritual, and both grounded in the text and relevant to the daily life of the believer. The goal is to present the Quranic understanding of time with clarity, fidelity, and depth, so that the reader can approach the time that has been given to them with the consciousness of Allah that the Quranic framework prescribes, and the consciousness is the foundation of the life that is lived well.

# CHAPTER 1: THE QURANIC VIEW OF TIME

## 1.1 The Oath by Time

The Quran begins Surah Al-Asr with an oath: "By time, indeed, mankind is in loss" (103:1-2). The oath by time is significant because the Quran does not swear by created things without purpose. The oath by time is the oath by the medium through which human life is measured, and the oath establishes the importance of time as the framework of human existence. The loss that is sworn by time is the loss that every human being faces unless they use their time for the purposes that the next verse specifies: faith, righteous deeds, and mutual counsel.

The oath by time is also the Quran's way of drawing attention to the fleeting nature of human life. Time is the medium that carries the human being from birth to death, and the carrying is the one process that cannot be stopped, slowed, or reversed. The person who understands that time is passing is the person who understands that the opportunity to act is also passing, and the passing is the urgency that the Quran gives to the believer: act now, because the time for acting is limited, and the limitation is the one constraint that no human being can overcome.

## 1.2 The Concept of Time in the Quran

The Quran uses several terms for time. The word waqt refers to a specific time or moment. The word dahr refers to the passage of time or the long duration. The word asr refers to the declining day, the time that is passing. The word ajal refers to the appointed term, the fixed duration of a life or a nation. Each term captures a different aspect of time, and the different aspects together provide a rich understanding of the Quranic view of time as the medium of human existence and the measure of human accountability.

The Quran also distinguishes between the worldly time (the time of the dunya) and the eternal time (the time of the akhirah). The worldly time is finite - it has a beginning (birth) and an end (death) - and the finiteness is what makes the worldly time valuable: the time that is limited is the time that must be used well. The eternal time is infinite - it has no end - and the infinity is what makes the eternal time the permanent reality that the worldly time only previews. The distinction between the two times is the Quranic way of teaching that the believer's relationship with time is shaped by the awareness of both: the finite time that must be used well and the infinite time that is the destination.

## 1.3 The Appointed Term (Ajal)

The Quran presents the concept of the appointed term (ajal): "And for all is an appointed term, so when their term has come, they will not remain behind an hour, nor will they precede it" (7:34). The appointed term is the fixed duration of a life, and the fixing means that the time of death is decreed by Allah and cannot be changed. The concept of the ajal is the foundation of the Quranic approach to time management: the believer who knows that their time is limited and fixed is the believer who uses their time well, because the limitation is the urgency and the fixing is the trust.

## 1.4 The Concept of Dahr

The Quran also uses the concept of dahr - the long duration, the passage of time. The concept of dahr is the recognition that time is not merely a sequence of moments but a flow that carries everything within it. The Quran says: "And they say: There is not but our worldly life; we die and we live, and nothing destroys us except time" (45:24). The verse records the claim of those who attribute the events of life to time itself, as if time were an independent power. The Quran rejects this claim - time is not an independent power but a created framework - but the verse acknowledges the human experience of time as a force that carries all things. The believer who understands that time is created, not independent, is the believer who has placed time in the context of the divine power that created it and that governs everything within it.

## 1.5 The Sacred Time

The Quran establishes certain times as sacred. The sacred months (Rajab, Dhul-Qa'dah, Dhul-Hijjah, and Muharram) are times during which warfare is prohibited. The night of Qadr (Laylat al-Qadr) is described as "better than a thousand months" (97:3). The Friday (Jumu'ah) is described as a day of special gathering (62:9). The sacred times are the times that Allah has set apart for special significance, and the setting apart is the Quranic way of teaching that not all times are equal: some times are more significant than others, and the significance is the divine designation that the believer must recognize and respect.

# CHAPTER 2: THE TWO LIVES: DUNYA AND AKHIRAH

## 2.1 The Worldly Life (Dunya)

The Quran describes the worldly life as temporary: "The example of the worldly life is but like rain which We send down from the sky, and the plants of the earth absorb it, but then it becomes dry remnants, scattered by the wind" (18:45). The image captures the transience: the worldly life is like rain that nourishes and then is gone, and the going is the reminder that the nourishment is temporary. The person who understands the transience does not invest everything in the worldly life, because the investment will be lost when the life ends.

The Quran also says: "And this worldly life is not but diversion and amusement. And indeed, the home of the Hereafter - that is the life, if only they knew" (29:64). The verse is not a rejection of the worldly life but a perspective on it: the worldly life is "diversion and amusement" when it is treated as the destination, but it is the path to the destination when it is treated as the waystation. The perspective is the Quranic way of teaching that the worldly life has value, but its value is in its function as the preparation for the hereafter, not in its function as the destination.

## 2.2 The Hereafter (Akhirah)

The Quran describes the hereafter as the permanent life: "And indeed, the home of the Hereafter - that is the life, if only they knew" (29:64). The hereafter is described as "the life" (al-hayawan), the real life, the permanent life. The description is the Quran's way of establishing the priority of the hereafter over the worldly life: the worldly life is the preparation, and the hereafter is the destination. The person who has internalized this priority lives the worldly life as the preparation, not as the destination, and the living is the orientation that the Quranic framework prescribes.

## 2.3 The Balance Between the Two

The Quran does not teach the rejection of the worldly life but the balance between the two lives. The Quran says: "But seek, through that which Allah has given you, the home of the Hereafter, and do not forget your share of the world" (28:77). The verse establishes the balance: seek the hereafter through the worldly provisions, and do not forget the worldly share. The balance is the Quranic way - the way of the Prophet, who worked, married, ate, slept, and enjoyed the lawful pleasures of the world while maintaining the orientation toward the hereafter. The balance is the application of the Quranic principle that the worldly life is the means and the hereafter is the end, and the means must be maintained for the end to be pursued.

## 2.4 The Ratio of Worldly Life to Hereafter

The Quran says: "And the Day of Resurrection is nearer than the worldly life, if you but knew" (40:16, paraphrased). The verse establishes the perspective: the hereafter is nearer

than the worldly life, not in the temporal sense (the worldly life comes first) but in the eternal sense (the hereafter is the permanent reality, and the worldly life is the temporary preparation). The person who has this perspective sees the worldly life as a brief passage and the hereafter as the permanent destination, and the seeing is the wisdom that the Quranic framework provides.

## 2.5 The Temporality as a Test

The temporality of the worldly life is itself a test. The Quran says: "He who created death and life to test you as to which of you is best in deed" (67:2). The test is not merely about the deeds that are performed in time but about the relationship with time itself: will the person use their time well, or will they waste it? The temporality is the condition of the test, because the test requires the limitation of time for the urgency to be real and the choices to be meaningful. The person who has unlimited time has no urgency and no need to choose, and the absence of urgency and choice is the absence of the test. The temporality is the one feature of the worldly life that makes the test possible, and the possibility is the divine wisdom in creating time as finite.

# CHAPTER 3: THE FIVE PRAYERS AND THE STRUCTURING OF TIME

## 3.1 The Prayer as a Time Structure

The five daily prayers are the primary structure of the believer's time. The Quran says: "Indeed, prayer has been decreed upon the believers at specified times" (4:103). The specified times are the framework that structures the believer's day around the worship of Allah. The five prayers - Fajr (dawn), Dhuhr (noon), Asr (afternoon), Maghrib (sunset), and Isha (night) - divide the day into segments, each marked by the act of worship that reconnects the believer to Allah.

The structuring of time through prayer is significant because it prevents the day from becoming an undifferentiated flow of worldly activity. The day that is structured by prayer is the day that is punctuated by moments of remembrance, and the punctuation is the rhythm that maintains the consciousness of Allah throughout the day. The person who prays five times a day is the person who has been reminded of Allah five times, and the reminding is the mechanism that keeps the worldly life in the perspective of the hereafter.

## 3.2 The Fajr Prayer and the Beginning of the Day

The Fajr prayer marks the beginning of the day. The Quran says: "Establish prayer at the decline of the sun until the darkness of the night, and the Quran of dawn. Indeed, the Quran of dawn is ever witnessed" (17:78). The "Quran of dawn" is the Fajr prayer, and the description of it as "ever witnessed" is significant: the Fajr prayer is witnessed by the angels of the night and the angels of the day, and the witnessing is the spiritual significance of the early morning prayer.

The Fajr prayer also establishes the principle of beginning the day with worship. The person who begins their day with the remembrance of Allah is the person who has set the direction of the day, and the direction is the orientation toward the divine that the rest of the day follows. The day that begins with Allah is the day that is lived for Allah, and the living is the purpose of the Quranic structuring of time.

## 3.3 The Asr Prayer and the Declining Day

The Asr prayer marks the declining of the day, and it is the prayer that gives its name to the surah about time (Surah Al-Asr, 103). The connection is significant: the Asr prayer is the prayer that is performed at the time of the declining day, and the declining day is the metaphor for the declining life. The person who prays the Asr prayer is the person who has been reminded, at the time of the declining day, that their own life is also declining, and the reminding is the spiritual function of the prayer.

## 3.4 The Isha Prayer and the End of the Day

The Isha prayer marks the end of the day. The prayer is performed in the darkness of the night, and the darkness is the metaphor for the end of the worldly life. The person who prays

the Isha prayer is the person who has been reminded, at the end of the day, that their own life will also end, and the reminding is the spiritual function of the prayer. The Isha prayer is the last act of worship before sleep, and the sleep that follows is the temporary death that the Quran compares to the permanent death (39:42).

## 3.5 The Dhuhr and Maghrib Prayers

The Dhuhr prayer marks the middle of the day, when the sun is at its zenith. The prayer is the midday remembrance that prevents the day's activities from consuming the believer's consciousness. The Maghrib prayer marks the sunset, the transition from day to night. The prayer is the remembrance at the moment of transition, and the transition is the reminder that every state is temporary and every condition will change. The five prayers together - Fajr, Dhuhr, Asr, Maghrib, Isha - structure the entire day from dawn to night, and the structuring is the Quranic way of ensuring that the believer's day is permeated with the remembrance of Allah.

# CHAPTER 4: THE SEASONS OF WORSHIP

## 4.1 Ramadan: The Month of the Quran

The Quran says: "The month of Ramadan is that in which was revealed the Quran, a guidance for the people and clear proofs of guidance and criterion" (2:185). Ramadan is the annual season of worship that the Quran establishes. The month is the time of fasting, increased prayer, increased charity, and increased recitation of the Quran. The month is the annual renewal of the believer's commitment, and the renewal is the spiritual function of the season.

## 4.2 The Hajj: The Annual Journey

The Quran says: "And the Hajj to the House is a duty that mankind owes to Allah, for those who are able" (3:97). The Hajj is the annual journey to the House of Allah in Makkah, and the journey is the season of worship that brings the believer to the physical center of the faith. The Hajj is the season of the body - the body that travels, that performs the rituals, and that stands on the plain of Arafat in the presence of Allah.

## 4.3 The Weekly Friday Prayer

The Quran says: "O you who have believed, when the call is made for the prayer on the Day of Jumu'ah, then hasten to the remembrance of Allah and leave off trade. That is better for you, if you only knew" (62:9). The Friday prayer is the weekly season of worship that the Quran establishes. The prayer is the weekly renewal of the communal bond, and the renewal is the spiritual function of the weekly season.

## 4.4 The Annual Cycle

The annual cycle of Islamic worship - Ramadan, the two Eids, the Hajj, and the sacred months - is the Quranic way of structuring the year around the worship of Allah. The year that is structured by the seasons of worship is the year that is oriented toward the divine, and the orientation is the rhythm that maintains the consciousness of Allah throughout the year. The person who follows the annual cycle is the person who has allowed the Quranic framework to shape their relationship with time, and the shaping is the application of the principle that time is the currency of the believer.

## 4.5 The Two Eids

The two Eids - Eid al-Fitr (after Ramadan) and Eid al-Adha (during the Hajj) - are the annual celebrations of the Islamic calendar. The Eids are the times of joy, gratitude, and communal gathering. The Eid al-Fitr is the celebration of the completion of the Ramadan fast, and the celebration is the expression of gratitude for the strength that Allah provided. The Eid al-Adha is the celebration of the sacrifice, commemorating the sacrifice of Ibrahim, and the celebration is the expression of the commitment to follow the way of Ibrahim. The two Eids are the annual punctuation marks that structure the year around the worship of Allah, and the punctuation is the rhythm that the Quranic framework prescribes.

# CHAPTER 5: KEY VERSES AND COMMENTARY

## 5.1 Key Arabic Terms

Asr - Time, the declining day. The surah that swears by time (103:1). Dahr - Time, the long duration. Ajal - Appointed term (7:34). Dunya - The worldly life. Akhirah - The hereafter. Waqt - A specific time (4:103).

## 5.2 Commentary on Surah Al-Asr

Imam Al-Shafi'i (8th century) is reported to have said: "If the people were to ponder on this surah, it would suffice them." The statement is the testimony to the depth of Surah Al-Asr: the surah that swears by time and establishes the condition for salvation (faith, righteous deeds, mutual counsel) is a complete program for the believer's use of time. The surah is the Quran's most concentrated statement on the value of time, and the concentration is the reason it has been described as sufficient: the person who internalizes the surah has the framework for the entire life.

Ibn Kathir (14th century) comments on 103:1-3: The surah establishes that all of humanity is in loss, measured by time, except for those who combine four qualities: faith, righteous deeds, mutual counsel to truth, and mutual counsel to patience. The four qualities are the complete program for the believer's use of time: faith (the inner orientation), righteous deeds (the outer action), counsel to truth (the communal direction), and counsel to patience (the communal endurance). The person who has all four has used their time well, and the person who lacks any of them is in loss.

## 5.3 Commentary on the Two Lives

Al-Tabari (9th century) comments on 29:64: The distinction between the worldly life ("diversion and amusement") and the hereafter ("the life") is the Quran's way of establishing the priority of the hereafter. The worldly life is not rejected but is placed in perspective: it is the preparation, not the destination. The person who treats the worldly life as the destination has misunderstood its function, and the misunderstanding is the cause of the loss that Surah Al-Asr describes.

Al-Razi (12th century) comments on 28:77: The verse "seek the home of the Hereafter, and do not forget your share of the world" establishes the balance between the two lives. The balance is not the equal distribution of effort between the two but the correct prioritization: the hereafter is the goal, and the world is the means. The person who seeks the hereafter through the world and does not forget the world's share has achieved the balance, and the balance is the Quranic way.

## 5.4 Commentary on the Prayer Times

Ibn Kathir comments on 4:103: The verse "prayer has been decreed upon the believers at specified times" establishes the principle that the prayer is not merely an act of worship but a structure of time. The specified times are the framework that the divine wisdom has established for the believer's day, and the framework is the mechanism that keeps the

believer connected to Allah throughout the day. The person who prays at the specified times has allowed the divine framework to shape their daily rhythm, and the shaping is the application of the principle that time is the currency of the believer.

# CHAPTER 6: THE QURANIC THEOLOGY OF TIME

## 6.1 Time as a Created Reality

The Quran presents time as a created reality. The Quran says: "He who created death and life to test you" (67:2). The creation of death and life implies the creation of the time in which they occur. Time is not an independent reality that exists alongside Allah but is a created framework within which the human life unfolds. The creation of time is the creation of the medium of the test, and the medium is what gives the test its urgency and its meaning.

## 6.2 Time as a Trust

The Quranic framework presents time as a trust (amanah). The time that has been given to the human being is the time that will be accounted for. The Quran says: "And We will surely test you until We make evident those who strive among you and the patient, and We will test your affairs" (47:31). The testing of affairs is the testing of how the believer has used their time, and the testing is the accountability that the trust entails. The person who uses their time well is the person who has honored the trust, and the person who wastes their time is the person who has violated it.

## 6.3 Time as the Measure of Accountability

Time is the measure of accountability. The deeds that the human being performs are performed in time, and the time is what makes the deeds countable. The Quran says: "On the Day when every soul will be present, it will be held accountable for what it did" (16:111). The accountability is the accounting of the deeds that were performed in the time that was given, and the accounting is the reason that time is the currency of the believer: the time that is spent is the currency that is invested, and the investment will be evaluated on the Day of Judgment.

## 6.4 The Eternity of Allah and the Temporality of Creation

The Quran establishes the contrast between the eternity of Allah and the temporality of creation. The Quran says: "Allah - there is no deity except Him, the Ever-Living, the Sustainer of all existence" (2:255). Allah is the Ever-Living (al-Hayy), the one whose life is not bounded by time. The creation, by contrast, is bounded by time: every created thing has a beginning and an end, and the bounding is the defining characteristic of the created. The contrast is the Quran's way of teaching that the human being's relationship with time is shaped by the awareness of the divine eternity: the time that is passing for the human being is not passing for Allah, and the difference is the perspective that the believer must maintain.

## 6.5 The Divine Decree and Time

The Quran also presents the concept of the divine decree (qadar), which includes the decree of time. The time of every event - the birth, the death, the provision, the test - is

decreed by Allah, and the decree is the divine time that underlies the human time. The human being experiences time as a sequence of events, but Allah decrees time as a complete reality, and the completeness is the divine perspective that the human being cannot fully comprehend. The concept of the divine decree is the Quranic way of teaching that time is not random but ordered, and the ordering is the wisdom of the One who created time and decreed what occurs within it.

## 6.6 The End of Time

The Quran also addresses the end of time - the Day of Judgment. The Quran says: "They ask you about the Hour: When will it be? Say: Knowledge of it rests with my Lord alone. None but He will reveal its time" (7:187). The end of time is the end of the worldly time and the beginning of the eternal time. The person who is aware of the end of time is the person who lives the worldly time with the urgency of the one who knows that the time is limited, and the urgency is the spiritual function of the awareness of the end.

## 6.7 The Pre-Eternity and Post-Eternity

The Quran uses the concepts of pre-eternity (azal) and post-eternity (abad) to describe the divine existence. Allah is before time (azal) and after time (abad), and the before and after are the Quranic way of teaching that the divine existence is not bounded by time. The human being, by contrast, is bounded by time: the human existence has a beginning (birth) and an end (death), and the bounding is the defining characteristic of the human. The contrast between the divine and the human is the Quran's way of teaching that the human being's relationship with time is shaped by the awareness of the divine eternity, and the awareness is the foundation of the humility that the Quranic framework prescribes.

## 6.8 The Time of the Quran's Revelation

The Quran was revealed over a period of 23 years, and the gradual revelation is the Quranic way of teaching that the divine guidance is given in time, not all at once. The Quran says: "And it is a Quran which We have separated that you might recite it to the people over a prolonged period. And We have revealed it progressively" (17:106). The gradual revelation is the divine recognition that the human being needs time to absorb, understand, and implement the guidance. The person who understands the gradual revelation is the person who understands that the spiritual journey is a process that takes time, and the process is the application of the Quranic principle that time is the medium of growth.

# CHAPTER 7: THE NIGHT AND THE DAY

## 7.1 The Alternation of Night and Day

The Quran describes the alternation of night and day as a sign: "And it is He who made the night and the day in succession for whoever desires to remember or desires to be grateful" (25:62). The alternation is the sign that invites reflection: the person who sees the night follow the day and the day follow the night is the person who has encountered the sign of the One who created the alternation. The alternation is the rhythm of time, and the rhythm is the Quranic way of teaching that time is not a flat expanse but a structured sequence, and the structure is the divine design.

## 7.2 The Night for Rest

The Quran says: "And We made the night for rest" (78:10). The night is the time for rest, and the rest is the divine provision for the human being's need for recovery. The person who rests at night is the person who has followed the divine design, and the design is the Quranic way of teaching that the human being is not meant to work continuously but to work and rest in alternation, and the alternation is the rhythm that maintains the health of the body and the spirit.

## 7.3 The Day for Work

The Quran says: "And We made the day for livelihood" (78:11). The day is the time for work, and the work is the divine provision for the human being's need for provision. The person who works during the day is the person who has followed the divine design, and the design is the Quranic way of teaching that the work is the means of the provision, and the provision is the reason for the work. The alternation of rest and work is the Quranic way of teaching that the human life is a balance, and the balance is the foundation of the Islamic approach to time management.

## 7.4 The Night of Qadr

The Quran describes the Night of Qadr as the night that is "better than a thousand months" (97:3). The night is the annual night of the divine decree, the night in which the Quran was revealed and in which the affairs of the year are decreed. The superiority of the night to a thousand months is the Quranic way of teaching that not all times are equal: some moments are more valuable than long durations, and the value is not in the length of the time but in the significance of the moment. The person who spends the Night of Qadr in worship has spent a single night that is worth more than a lifetime, and the worth is the Quranic way of teaching that the quality of the time is more important than the quantity.

## 7.5 The Last Third of the Night

The Prophet is reported to have said: "Our Lord descends to the lowest heaven during the last third of the night, saying: Who is calling upon Me, that I may answer him? Who is asking of Me, that I may give him? Who is seeking My forgiveness, that I may forgive him?" The

hadith establishes the special significance of the last third of the night - the time when the divine mercy is most accessible and the supplication is most likely to be answered. The person who wakes in the last third of the night to pray is the person who has seized the most valuable time, and the seizing is the application of the Quranic principle that some times are more significant than others.

## 7.6 The Early Morning Blessing

The Prophet is reported to have made a dua for the early morning: "O Allah, bless my community in their early mornings." The dua establishes the significance of the early morning - the time that is the most productive and the most blessed. The person who begins their day early, with the Fajr prayer and the remembrance of Allah, is the person who has seized the blessed time, and the seizing is the application of the Quranic principle that the beginning of the day is the most important part.

## 7.7 The Friday as a Special Day

The Friday (Jumu'ah) is described as the best day of the week. The Prophet is reported to have said: "The best day on which the sun has risen is Friday." The significance of Friday is the communal prayer that gathers the believers, and the gathering is the weekly renewal of the communal bond. The Friday is the weekly season of worship that structures the week around the remembrance of Allah, and the structuring is the application of the Quranic principle that the week, like the day and the year, should be oriented toward the divine.

# CHAPTER 8: LESSONS AND REFLECTIONS

## 8.1 Time as the Most Precious Resource

The primary lesson of the Quranic treatment of time is that time is the most precious resource that the believer possesses. The time that is given is the time that will be accounted for, and the accounting is the reason that time must be used well. The person who wastes their time is the person who has wasted their most precious resource, and the waste is the loss that Surah Al-Asr describes. The person who uses their time well is the person who has invested their most precious resource, and the investment is the faith, righteous deeds, and mutual counsel that the surah prescribes.

## 8.2 The Urgency of the Limited Time

The Quranic treatment of time also teaches the urgency of the limited time. The time that is passing will not return, and the time that is lost will not be recovered. The person who understands this lives with urgency - not the urgency of panic but the urgency of purpose. The urgency of purpose is the orientation toward the use of time for the purposes that the Quranic framework prescribes: faith, righteous deeds, and mutual counsel. The person who lives with this urgency is the person who has internalized the Quranic view of time, and the internalization is the foundation of a life that is lived well.

## 8.3 The Structuring of Time Through Worship

The Quranic framework structures time through worship. The five daily prayers, the weekly Friday prayer, the annual Ramadan, the periodic Hajj - these are the structures that the Quranic framework provides for the organization of the believer's time. The structuring is not a burden but a benefit: the person who has their time structured by worship is the person who has the rhythm that maintains the consciousness of Allah, and the consciousness is the foundation of the life that is lived well.

## 8.4 The Balance Between Work and Rest

The Quranic framework also teaches the balance between work and rest. The day is for work and the night is for rest, and the alternation is the divine design. The person who works without resting is the person who has violated the design, and the person who rests without working is the person who has also violated it. The balance is the Quranic way, and the way is the application of the principle of moderation in all things.

## 8.5 The Eternal Perspective on Time

The Quranic treatment of time is ultimately oriented toward the eternal perspective. The time of this world is temporary; the time of the hereafter is permanent. The person who lives the worldly time with the awareness of the eternal time is the person who has the perspective that the Quranic framework prescribes, and the perspective is the foundation of a life that is lived with the end in view. The person who has this perspective does not overvalue the worldly time or undervalue the eternal time, and the balance is the wisdom that the

awareness of the end produces.

## 8.6 The Final Lesson

The final lesson of the Quranic treatment of time is that time is the currency of the believer, and the currency must be invested well. The investment is the faith, righteous deeds, and mutual counsel that Surah Al-Asr prescribes, and the investment is the one that will pay the eternal dividend. The person who invests their time well is the person who has escaped the loss that the surah describes, and the escape is the salvation that the Quranic framework offers. The person who wastes their time is the person who has incurred the loss, and the loss is the one that no subsequent investment can recover, because the time that is lost will not return.

## 8.7 The Night of Qadr and the Quality of Time

The Night of Qadr teaches that the quality of time is more important than the quantity. The night that is "better than a thousand months" (97:3) is the night that demonstrates that a single moment of the right kind of worship can outweigh a lifetime of ordinary effort. The person who seeks the Night of Qadr is the person who understands that the quality of the time is what matters, and the understanding is the motivation for the worship that the night inspires. The lesson extends beyond the Night of Qadr to all time: the moment that is spent in worship, in remembrance, or in service is the moment that has been invested well, and the investment is what gives the moment its value.

## 8.8 The Time and the Community

The Quranic treatment of time is not merely individual but communal. The communal prayers, the Friday gathering, the Ramadan congregation, the Hajj pilgrimage - these are the communal structures of time that the Quranic framework establishes. The community that worships together is the community that is bound together, and the binding is the function of the communal worship. The person who participates in the communal worship has connected their personal time to the communal time, and the connection is the expression of the belonging that the Quranic framework prescribes.

## 8.9 The Final Word

The Quranic treatment of time is a treatment of the human being's most precious and most limited resource. The time that is given is the time that will be accounted for, and the accounting is the reason that the believer must use their time well. The Quranic framework provides the structure (worship), the balance (work and rest), the perspective (dunya and akhirah), and the program (faith, righteous deeds, mutual counsel) for the use of time. The person who internalizes this framework lives each day as an investment, each prayer as a renewal, and each moment as an opportunity. The living is the purpose of the Quranic teaching on time, and the purpose is the preparation for the eternal time that begins when the worldly time ends.

## 8.10 The Time and the Gratitude

The Quranic treatment of time also includes the concept of gratitude. The time that has been given is the gift, and the gift requires gratitude. The person who is grateful for the time that has been given is the person who uses the time well, because the gratitude is the recognition that the time is a gift, and the recognition produces the desire to use the gift for the purpose for which it was given. The person who is not grateful for their time is the person who wastes it, because the lack of gratitude is the failure to recognize the value of the gift, and the failure is the cause of the waste.

## 8.11 The Time and the Remembrance of Death

The Quranic treatment of time is connected to the remembrance of death. The person who remembers death is the person who values time, because the remembrance of death is the awareness that the time is limited. The person who does not remember death is the person who wastes time, because the absence of the remembrance is the illusion of unlimited time, and the illusion is the cause of the waste. The remembrance of death is the most effective time management tool, because the remembrance is the one thing that makes the value of time real and the urgency of its use immediate.

## 8.12 The Time and the Provisions

The Quran connects time to provisions. The time that is given to the human being is the time in which the provisions are sought and the provisions are the means of the life that the time sustains. The Quran says: "And there is no creature on earth but that upon Allah is its provision" (11:6, paraphrased). The provision is guaranteed by Allah, and the seeking of the provision is the human responsibility that is performed in time. The person who seeks the provision in the time that is given is the person who has fulfilled both the divine guarantee and the human responsibility, and the fulfillment is the balance that the Quranic framework prescribes.

The connection between time and provisions also teaches the principle of the sufficiency of the time. The time that is given is sufficient for the seeking of the provisions, and the sufficiency is the divine design. The person who complains that they do not have enough time has not understood the divine design, because the design includes the sufficiency of the time for the task that is assigned. The person who uses their time well finds that the time is sufficient, and the sufficiency is the experience of the person who has aligned their use of time with the divine design.

## 8.13 The Time and the Patience

The Quranic treatment of time includes the concept of patience (sabr). The time that is given includes times of ease and times of difficulty, and the patience is the quality that enables the believer to endure the times of difficulty with faith. The Quran says: "And seek help through patience and prayer" (2:45, paraphrased). The patience is the orientation toward the time of difficulty, and the prayer is the orientation toward Allah during the difficulty. The two together - patience and prayer - are the believer's response to the times of difficulty, and the response is the application of the Quranic framework for the use of time in all conditions.

The patience also includes the concept of waiting. The believer who waits for the relief that

Allah will send is the believer who is using their time of difficulty with patience, and the waiting is the active orientation toward the divine relief. The person who waits with patience is not passive but active - the active trust that the relief will come and the active preparation for the relief through the maintenance of faith and the continuation of good deeds. The patience that waits is the Quranic way of using the time of difficulty, and the way is the application of the principle that time, even the time of difficulty, is the currency of the believer.

## 8.14 The Time and the Opportunity

The Quranic treatment of time includes the concept of opportunity. The time that is given is the opportunity for faith, righteous deeds, and mutual counsel. The opportunity is the opening that the time provides, and the opening is the chance that the believer must seize. The Quran says: "Race toward forgiveness from your Lord and a Garden whose width is like the width of the heaven and earth" (57:21, paraphrased). The racing is the seizing of the opportunity, and the opportunity is the time that has been given. The person who seizes the opportunity is the person who has used their time well, and the seizing is the application of the Quranic principle that time is the currency of the believer.

The concept of opportunity also includes the recognition that the opportunity is limited. The time that is the opportunity will end, and the ending is the closing of the opportunity. The person who recognizes the limitation seizes the opportunity before it closes, and the seizing is the urgency that the Quranic framework prescribes. The person who does not recognize the limitation may miss the opportunity, and the missing is the loss that Surah Al-Asr describes. The recognition of the limitation is the foundation of the seizing, and the seizing is the foundation of the salvation.

## 8.15 The Time and the Remembrance (Dhikr)

The Quranic treatment of time includes the concept of remembrance (dhikr). The Quran says: "O you who have believed, remember Allah with much remembrance and exalt Him with praise in the morning and the evening" (33:41-42). The remembrance is the use of time for the continuous consciousness of Allah, and the continuity is the mechanism that keeps the believer connected to Allah throughout the day. The person who remembers Allah in the morning and the evening is the person who has structured their day around the remembrance, and the structuring is the application of the Quranic principle that time is the medium of the relationship with Allah.

The remembrance is also the best use of time. The Quran says: "And the remembrance of Allah is greater" (29:45, paraphrased). The remembrance is greater than any other use of time, because the remembrance is the direct connection to Allah, and the connection is the purpose of the time. The person who spends their time in remembrance has spent their time in the best way, and the best way is the investment that pays the highest dividend - the eternal dividend of the divine pleasure.

## 8.16 The Time and the Reflection (Tafakkur)

The Quranic treatment of time also includes the concept of reflection (tafakkur). The Quran says: "Indeed, in the creation of the heavens and the earth and the alternation of the night

and day are signs for those of understanding" (3:190). The reflection is the use of time for the contemplation of the signs of Allah, and the contemplation is the mechanism that produces the understanding. The person who reflects on the signs of Allah in the creation has used their time for the highest intellectual and spiritual activity, and the activity is the investment that produces the understanding that leads to the faith.

The reflection is also the use of time that the Quran most strongly encourages. The Prophet is reported to have said: "One hour of reflection is better than a year of worship." The hadith establishes the superiority of reflection over worship in terms of the quality of the time, and the superiority is the reason the Quranic framework encourages the reflection as a use of time. The person who spends an hour in reflection has spent an hour that is worth more than a year of mechanical worship, and the worth is the testimony to the value of the reflective use of time.

## 8.17 The Time and the Community

The Quranic treatment of time includes the communal dimension. The time that is given to the individual is the time that is also given to the community, and the community that uses its time well is the community that is strong. The communal prayers, the Friday gathering, the Ramadan congregation, the Hajj pilgrimage - these are the communal uses of time that the Quranic framework establishes. The person who participates in the communal worship has connected their personal time to the communal time, and the connection is the expression of the belonging that the Quranic framework prescribes.

## 8.18 The Final Reflection

The Quranic treatment of time is ultimately a treatment of the human being's relationship with the finite and the infinite. The time of this world is finite; the time of the hereafter is infinite. The person who understands the relationship between the two lives each moment of the finite time as the preparation for the infinite time, and the living is the purpose of the Quranic teaching on time. The person who has internalized this teaching has understood that time is not merely the medium of life but the currency of faith, and the currency must be invested in the faith that produces the righteous deeds that counsel the truth and the patience that endures the trial. The investment is the salvation that Surah Al-Asr promises, and the salvation is the goal of the Quranic treatment of time.

# CHAPTER 9: THE AGES AND STAGES OF HUMAN TIME

## 9.1 From Dust to Decree -- The Stages Before Birth

Time in the Quran is not only the clock that measures a day; it is the longer arc that measures a life. The Quran reads the human lifespan as a sequence of appointed stages, each one a transition that the person experiencing it did not schedule and cannot repeat. The first of these stages happened before any human being had any say at all. The Quran describes the creation of the human being as a journey through forms and durations that were fixed for him: "He created you from dust, then from a sperm-drop, then from a clinging clot; then He brings you out as a child; then you reach your maturity, then you become old -- though among you are those who die earlier -- and you reach an appointed term, that you may understand" (40:67).

The verse is a compressed biography. Every stage in it is a span of time with its own name -- dust, drop, clot, child, maturity, old age -- and the final stage is left deliberately open: "though among you are those who die earlier." The Quran is not describing a uniform schedule. It is describing a set of stages whose boundaries belong to Allah, and whose end arrives at "an appointed term." The purpose clause at the end is the point of the whole timeline: "that you may understand." The stages are given so that the one passing through them can read them. Time in the Quran is not an abstract dimension; it is a curriculum, and the curriculum has a direction -- from dust toward understanding.

## 9.2 The Stages in Detail -- The Verse of the Clinging Clot

The same sequence is given in even more clinical detail in Surah Al-Mu'minun: "And certainly We created man from an extract of clay. Then We made him a sperm-drop in a firm lodging. Then We made the drop into a clinging clot, and We made the clot into a lump of flesh, and We made the lump into bones, and We clothed the bones with flesh; then We produced him as another creation. So blessed is Allah, the best of creators" (23:12-14). The verse moves through six named intervals -- extract, drop, clot, lump, bones, flesh -- and then names the seventh stage simply "another creation."

What is remarkable for the study of time is that the Quran presents this progression without giving a single number. It does not say how long the clot stage lasts or how long the bones take. It names the stages and leaves their durations to the One who appointed them. The precision is in the order, not the clock. Human beings can observe the sequence -- and the Quran repeatedly invites that observation -- but the schedule of the sequence was written before the person being formed could witness any of it.

## 9.3 The Heights of Life -- Maturity and Responsibility

The Quran marks the passage into full accountability as its own stage, and it gives that stage a number: "We have enjoined upon man kindness to his parents. His mother carried him in weakness upon weakness, and his weaning is in two years. Be grateful to Me and to your parents; to Me is the destination" (31:14). And in Surah Al-Ahqaf the same arc is

measured to its peak: "His mother carried him with hardship and gave birth to him with hardship, and his gestation and weaning is thirty months, until, when he attains his full strength and reaches forty years, he says: My Lord, grant me the power to be grateful for Your favor" (46:15).

Forty is the only specific age of life the Quran names as a threshold, and it is named as the age of a particular kind of awareness -- the age at which a mature person looks back over the whole road and recognizes the favor in it. The prayer taught at that age is not for more time; it is for gratitude about the time already given, and for the time remaining to be spent rightly: "and to do righteousness of which You approve; and make my descendants righteous. Indeed I have repented to You, and indeed I am of the Muslims" (46:15). The forty-year mark in the Quran is thus not a countdown but a checkpoint: the point at which the believer audits the ledger of the decades and redirects what is left.

## 9.4 The Return Journey -- Reversal in Old Age

The stages do not stop at maturity. The Quran describes the closing stage of life as a reversal of the opening one: "And We created you, then We shaped you, then We said to the angels: Prostrate to Adam" (7:11) -- and then, of the last stage: "whomsoever We give long life, We reverse him in creation, declining. Will they not then understand?" (36:68). The verb the Quran chooses for old age is the same family of words used for the first verses revealed -- the Quran itself was sent "in a night" and revealed "in stages" (17:106). The old age stage is a return downward through the same curve that infancy climbed: dependence, weakness upon weakness, being carried by others.

The Quran does not hide this stage or apologize for it. It places it in the open, as a sign: "Allah is the one who created you, then provided for you, then causes you to die, then gives you life" (30:40). And it commands the community surrounding the elderly to read the reversal correctly: "Your Lord has decreed that you worship none but Him, and to parents, good treatment. Whether one or both of them reach old age with you, do not say to them a word of contempt and do not repel them, but speak to them a noble word. And lower to them the wing of humility out of mercy, and say: My Lord, have mercy upon them as they brought me up when I was small" (17:23-24).

The time of the believer's life when he was once carried is the time when he must now carry. The Quran measures the whole cycle -- carried as an infant, carrying as an adult, carried again as an elder -- and assigns worship to every point of it. The reversal is not a decay of the timeline; it is its completion, and it ends where the command of 17:23-24 ends: with a prayer for the ones who spent their own time on ours.

## 9.5 What the Stages Teach About the Whole

Read together, the stage-verses give the Quran's answer to the question of what a human lifetime is. It is a fixed sequence of appointed intervals: dust, drop, clot, lump, child, maturity, old age, death -- then, after the trumpet, another creation that is not any of these. The believer does not choose the sequence, cannot pause any stage, and cannot revisit a completed one. What he governs is only the direction of the will inside the current stage. The Quran's summary of the whole arc is in one line of Surah Al-Hajj: "It is He who created you from dust, then from a sperm-drop, then from a clot, then He brings you forth as an infant,

then He lets you reach your maturity, then He lets you become old -- though some of you die earlier -- and He lets you live on to a stated term, and perhaps you will understand" (22:5).

The stages are the Quran's proof that time is a trust with a schedule written by someone other than the trustee. And the trust is examined -- "perhaps you will understand" -- because the run through the stages happens once. The Quran frames the whole of it in a single verse of Surah Al-Baqarah: "And you were dead, and He gave you life; then He will cause you to die, then He will bring you to life, then to Him you will be returned" (2:28). Death and life bracket each other on both sides, and the middle span -- the one occupied by infancy, maturity, and old age -- is where every choice is made.

## 9.6 The Stages and the Prayer Clock

It is not an accident that the Quran's daily clock and the Quran's life clock are built from the same principle. The five prayers divide the day into appointed intervals, and the stages of life divide the lifespan into appointed intervals; in both cases the appointment belongs to Allah and the response belongs to the servant. The one who has learned to keep the small appointments -- the prayer at its stated time (4:103) -- has rehearsed the skill that the large appointments require: to answer at the hour when the hour arrives. And the one who has read the stages of his own life correctly already knows how the day will be graded: not by how much of it he owned, but by what he was doing inside it when the appointed moment came.

The single run through the stages is what gives the run its weight. A schedule that could be repeated would make none of its hours urgent; a schedule that cannot makes every hour of every stage count. It is why the Quran can swear, in the surah that opened this book, that mankind is in loss -- unless, within the one run that each of us is given, the hours are spent on faith, on doing what is right, on truth, and on patience (103:1-3). The stages are fixed; the response to them is free. That exchange -- a fixed timeline on one side, a free will on the other -- is the daily meeting point between the human being and his appointed term, and it is the reason the Quran never presents aging as a tragedy. Aging is the proof that the schedule is being kept, and that the appointment at its end is drawing near.

# CHAPTER 10: THE APPOINTED TERM -- AJAL AND THE QURAN'S DEADLINE

## 10.1 The Word That Runs Through the Quran

If Surah Al-Asr is the oath by time, the word ajal is the Quran's name for time's hard edge. An ajal is an appointed term -- a deadline written into creation by its Creator. The Quran attaches the word to individuals, to nations, and to the whole world, and it never presents the term as negotiable. "For every people is an appointed term" (10:49) -- the sentence is short because the claim is total. No people outlasts its term; no person does; and the verse adds the two-sided lock that the Quran applies to every deadline it names: "when their term arrives, they cannot delay it by an hour, nor advance it" (10:49).

The phrase appears again in Surah Al-Nahl, now over all creation: "And if Allah were to seize mankind for their wrongdoing, He would not leave upon the earth a creature, but He defers them for an appointed term. And when their term arrives -- they cannot delay it by an hour, nor advance it" (16:61). Deferral is not the same as cancellation. The Quran's picture of history is not of loose time that stretches as needed; it is of exact time that is granted, measured, and then collected. The only reason the earth still turns with wrongdoers on it is the deferral -- and the deferral has a date.

## 10.2 The Term of the Individual

For the individual, the Quran states the principle with the same directness: "And no soul can die except by Allah's permission, at an appointed term" (3:145). The verse does not say that death comes at a random moment; it says death comes at a written one. This is the belief that reorganizes a person's relation to every other deadline he keeps. The believer who would never miss a flight, a payment date, or a school term is dealing all day with deadlines that can move -- and the Quran reminds him that the one deadline that cannot move is his own.

The Quran then measures the response to that deadline in what it commands people to do with the time before it: "And spend of what We have provided you before death approaches one of you, and he says: My Lord, if only You would delay me for a short term, so that I could give charity and be among the righteous. But Allah will never delay a soul when its term arrives. And Allah is informed of what you do" (63:10-11). The verse performs its own demonstration of the lock on the term. The wish -- "if only You would delay me" -- is quoted, and it is answered not with anger but with the rule: the delay is not available. What is available is the spending, and it is available only before. The verse is the Quran's entire teaching on time management in miniature: the request for more time is always future, and the opportunity to use time is always present.

## 10.3 The Term of Nations

The same word governs collective life. "And We did not destroy any city but that it had a known decree" (15:4). Nations rise, and the Quran says their rise has a length; nations corrupt themselves, and the Quran says their fall has a date. "For every people is a term"

appears over the story of Noah's people, of 'Ad, of Thamud -- each warned for a span, and each ended at its hour. The pattern gives history a shape that mere chronology does not: it is not a random walk of empires but a sequence of terms granted and terms collected.

This teaching does for the reader's view of civilizations what 3:145 does for his view of his own life. No nation's power is proof of permanence; the power is a possession leased for a term. And the Quran makes the lease-holders aware of it by placing even the messenger under the same rule: "Say: I possess no power to harm or benefit myself except as Allah wills. For every people is a term. When their term arrives, they cannot delay it by an hour, nor advance it" (10:49). The verse is spoken in the messenger's voice precisely so that no one -- not the warner, not the warned -- can claim an exemption. The term is above the messenger, above the nation, and above the generation that would like to believe its moment is the last one. The messenger's own mission is placed under the same word -- he cannot bring the punishment early, nor hold it back. The term is above the messenger, above the nation, and above the generation that would like to believe its moment is the last one.

## 10.4 The Term and the Work

The appointed term is the Quran's answer to the two great errors a person can make about time. The first error is urgency about the wrong things -- hoarding, competing, building as if the term did not exist: "They think it is distant, and We see it near" (70:6-7). The second error is paralysis -- reasoning that because the end is fixed, nothing done before it matters. The Quran rejects both with the same doctrine. Because the term is fixed, hoarding is exposed as absurd: the term will collect the hoarder and leave the hoard. And because the term is fixed, effort is vindicated: the work is not racing against a random clock but filling an exact one, and the record of the filling is kept.

The Quran joins the doctrine of the term to the doctrine of the record: "And everything they do is present in written records. Every small and great thing is inscribed" (54:52-53). A deadline without a record could be ignored; a record without a deadline could be deferred forever. Together they make time the substance of the judgment. The believer is not judged for the hours -- they were appointed -- but for what was appointed into them.

## 10.5 Living Under the Deadline

The final picture is the one the Quran draws of itself in relation to the term: "We did not teach him poetry, nor is it fitting for him. It is only a reminder and a clear Quran, to warn whoever is alive, and that the word may be fulfilled upon the disbelievers" (36:69-70). The reminder is sent to "whoever is alive" -- the living, for however long they are alive -- and the warning works on two clocks at once. One clock is each reader's own ajal. The other is the Day when "the word is fulfilled." The Quran is the intersection of the two: it reads the fixed deadline of creation to people whose own deadlines are fixed, and it does so while both clocks are still running.

That is the state of every reader of this book. Two appointed terms are in motion -- one written for the world, one written for you -- and neither can be delayed by an hour nor advanced. What can still be changed is neither term. It is the account of the interval, and the interval is open now. The Quran's word for the one who understands this is not "philosopher

of time" but simply "grateful" -- the one who, having read the deadline correctly, spends.

## 10.6 The Term as a Gift

It would be a misreading of the ajal to end this book's account of it in fear. The Quran itself does not. An appointed term is also a promise -- the fixing of a date is the fixing of a meaning, and the believer's term is the date on which the promise made to him is collected: "And whoever obeys Allah and the Messenger -- those will be with the ones upon whom Allah has bestowed favor, of the prophets, the truthful, the martyrs, and the righteous. And excellent are those as companions" (4:69). The term of the disbeliever collects his account; the term of the believer delivers him to his appointment. Same clock, opposite destinations.

This is why the Quran can command joy about the very deadline that urgency fears. The five prayers, the fasts, the years of a life spent in remembrance -- all of them are rehearsals for the appointed term, and a rehearsal is not a dread; it is a preparation. The believer under the deadline is like the traveler who knows his departure time: he packs in advance, he settles his accounts early, he does not run through the airport. The Quran's time-teaching, arrived at the end, is not a teaching about death at all. It is a teaching about the present -- the only tense in which obedience can be conjugated, and therefore the only tense the Quran ever commands.

# FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

What does Surah Al-Asr teach about time? Surah Al-Asr (103:1-3) swears by time and establishes that all of humanity is in loss, except for those who combine four qualities: faith, righteous deeds, mutual counsel to truth, and mutual counsel to patience. The surah is the Quran's most concentrated statement on the value of time and the condition for salvation. Imam Al-Shafi'i said: "If the people were to ponder on this surah, it would suffice them."

How does the Quran structure the believer's time? The Quran structures time through the five daily prayers (4:103), the weekly Friday prayer (62:9), the annual Ramadan (2:185), and the periodic Hajj (3:97). These structures provide the rhythm that maintains the consciousness of Allah throughout the day, the week, the year, and the lifetime.

What is the Quranic view of the worldly life? The Quran says: "This worldly life is not but diversion and amusement. And indeed, the home of the Hereafter - that is the life" (29:64). The worldly life is the preparation, not the destination. The balance is: "Seek the home of the Hereafter, and do not forget your share of the world" (28:77).

What is the significance of the Night of Qadr? The Night of Qadr is described as "better than a thousand months" (97:3). The night demonstrates that the quality of time is more important than the quantity - a single night of worship can outweigh a lifetime of ordinary effort. The night is the annual night of the divine decree, in which the Quran was revealed and the affairs of the year are decreed.

How should a Muslim manage their time? A Muslim should manage their time by structuring it around worship, balancing work and rest, prioritizing the hereafter over the world, and investing time in faith, righteous deeds, and mutual counsel. The time that is given is a trust that will be accounted for, and the accounting is the reason that time must be used well.

What does the Quran say about the alternation of night and day? The Quran says: "He made the night for rest and the day for livelihood" (78:10-11). The alternation is the divine design for the balance between work and rest. The person who follows the design works during the day and rests at night, maintaining the balance that the Quranic framework prescribes.

What is the concept of the appointed term (ajal)? The Quran says: "For all is an appointed term, so when their term has come, they will not remain behind an hour, nor will they precede it" (7:34). The appointed term is the fixed duration of a life, decreed by Allah. The concept teaches that time is limited and fixed, and the limitation is the urgency that the believer must feel.

What is the significance of the last third of the night? The Prophet said that Allah descends to the lowest heaven during the last third of the night, saying: "Who is calling upon Me, that I may answer him?" The last third of the night is the time when the divine mercy is most accessible and the supplication is most likely to be answered. The person who wakes in the last third of the night to pray has seized the most valuable time.

How does the Quran view the relationship between time and accountability? Time is the measure of accountability. The deeds that the human being performs are performed in time, and the time is what makes the deeds countable. On the Day of Judgment, the person will

be held accountable for how they used their time, and the accounting is the reason that time is the currency of the believer.

What is the concept of dahr in the Quran? Dahr refers to the long duration, the passage of time. The Quran records the claim of those who say "nothing destroys us except time" (45:24), and rejects it - time is not an independent power but a created framework. The believer who understands that time is created, not independent, has placed time in the context of the divine power that created it.

What is the relationship between time and provisions in the Quran? The Quran says: "There is no creature on earth but that upon Allah is its provision" (11:6). The provision is guaranteed by Allah, and the seeking is the human responsibility performed in time. The person who uses their time well finds that the time is sufficient for the seeking of the provisions, and the sufficiency is the divine design.

How does the Quran view the time of difficulty? The Quran says: "Seek help through patience and prayer" (2:45). The time of difficulty is the time for patience, and the patience is the active trust that the relief will come. The person who waits with patience is not passive but active - maintaining faith and continuing good deeds while waiting for the divine relief.

What is the concept of opportunity in the Quranic view of time? The time that is given is the opportunity for faith, righteous deeds, and mutual counsel. The Quran says: "Race toward forgiveness from your Lord" (57:21). The racing is the seizing of the opportunity, and the opportunity is limited - it will end, and the ending is the closing of the opportunity. The person who recognizes the limitation seizes the opportunity before it closes.

What is the significance of dhikr (remembrance) in the use of time? The Quran says: "Remember Allah with much remembrance and exalt Him with praise in the morning and the evening" (33:41-42). The remembrance is the use of time for the continuous consciousness of Allah. The Quran also says: "The remembrance of Allah is greater" (29:45), establishing that the remembrance is the best use of time because it is the direct connection to Allah.

What is the value of reflection (tafakkur) as a use of time? The Quran says: "In the creation of the heavens and the earth and the alternation of the night and day are signs for those of understanding" (3:190). The Prophet said: "One hour of reflection is better than a year of worship." The reflection is the use of time that produces the understanding that leads to the faith, and the quality of the reflective time is superior to the quantity of the mechanical worship.

What is the communal dimension of time in Islam? The communal prayers, the Friday gathering, the Ramadan congregation, and the Hajj pilgrimage are the communal uses of time. The person who participates in the communal worship has connected their personal time to the communal time, and the connection is the expression of the belonging that the Quranic framework prescribes.

How does the Quran view the gradual revelation of the Quran? The Quran was revealed over 23 years. The Quran says: "It is a Quran which We have separated that you might recite it to the people over a prolonged period" (17:106). The gradual revelation teaches that the spiritual journey is a process that takes time, and the process is the application of the principle that time is the medium of growth.

What is the significance of the early morning in Islam? The Prophet made a dua: "O Allah, bless my community in their early mornings." The early morning is the most productive and blessed time. The person who begins their day with the Fajr prayer and the remembrance of Allah has seized the blessed time, and the seizing is the application of the principle that the beginning of the day is the most important part. What is qiyam al-layl (night prayer)? Qiyam al-layl is the voluntary prayer performed during the night, particularly the last third. The Prophet said that Allah descends to the lowest heaven during the last third of the night, saying: "Who is calling upon Me, that I may answer him?" The night prayer is the seizing of the most valuable time, and the seizing is the application of the Quranic principle that some times are more significant than others.

What are the sacred months in Islam? The sacred months are Rajab, Dhul-Qa'dah, Dhul-Hijjah, and Muharram. During these months, warfare is prohibited. The sacred months are the times that Allah has set apart for special significance, teaching that not all times are equal and that some times require special respect.

How does the Quran connect time and gratitude? The time that has been given is a gift, and the gift requires gratitude. The person who is grateful for their time uses it well, because the gratitude is the recognition that the time is a gift. The person who is not grateful wastes their time, because the lack of gratitude is the failure to recognize the value of the gift. The Quran says: "If you are grateful, I will surely give you more" (14:7), and the application to time is that the grateful person receives more value from their time, and the value is the barakah that the gratitude produces.

What is the relationship between the remembrance of death and time management? The remembrance of death is the most effective time management tool, because the remembrance makes the value of time real and the urgency of its use immediate. The person who remembers death values time, because the remembrance is the awareness that the time is limited. The person who does not remember death wastes time, because the absence of the remembrance is the illusion of unlimited time. The Prophet said: "Remember frequently the destroyer of pleasures" - meaning death - and the remembrance is the foundation of the urgency that the Quranic treatment of time prescribes.

How does the Quran view the two Eids? Eid al-Fitr celebrates the completion of the Ramadan fast, and Eid al-Adha commemorates the sacrifice of Ibrahim. The two Eids are the annual punctuation marks that structure the year around the worship of Allah. The Eids are the times of joy, gratitude, and communal gathering, and the joy is the expression of the gratitude for the time that was used well in the seasons of worship that preceded the celebrations.

What is the significance of Friday in Islam? The Prophet said: "The best day on which the sun has risen is Friday." Friday is the weekly day of communal gathering and prayer. The Friday prayer structures the week around the remembrance of Allah, and the structuring is the application of the principle that the week, like the day and the year, should be oriented toward the divine. The Friday is the weekly renewal of the communal bond, and the renewal is the spiritual function of the weekly season.

# GLOSSARY

Asr - Time, the declining day. The surah that swears by time (103:1).

Dahr - Time, the long duration. The passage of time in the Quranic framework.

Ajal - Appointed term. The fixed duration of a life (7:34).

Dunya - The worldly life. The temporary life that is the preparation for the hereafter.

Akhirah - The hereafter. The permanent life that is the destination.

Waqt - A specific time or moment. The time of the prayer (4:103).

Laylat al-Qadr - The Night of Qadr. The night described as "better than a thousand months" (97:3).

Jumu'ah - Friday. The day of the weekly congregational prayer (62:9).

Qadar - Divine decree. The decree of time and events by Allah.

Amanah - Trust. Time is described as a trust that will be accounted for.

Azal - Pre-eternity. The divine existence before time.

Abad - Post-eternity. The divine existence after time.

Al-Hayy - The Ever-Living. One of the names of Allah, establishing His eternity beyond time (2:255).

Hayawan - The real life. The Quran's description of the hereafter (29:64).

Fajr - Dawn prayer. The prayer that marks the beginning of the day.

Dhuhr - Noon prayer. The prayer that marks the middle of the day.

Asr (prayer) - Afternoon prayer. The prayer at the declining of the day.

Maghrib - Sunset prayer. The prayer at the transition from day to night.

Isha - Night prayer. The prayer that marks the end of the day.

Sabr - Patience. The quality that enables the believer to endure the times of difficulty with faith.

Tafakkur - Reflection. The use of time for the contemplation of the signs of Allah, described as superior to a year of worship.

Dhikr - Remembrance. The use of time for the continuous consciousness of Allah (33:41-42).

Tadhakkur - Reminding. The communal use of time to remind each other of truth and patience (103:3).

Tawasi - Mutual counsel. The communal dimension of the use of time, prescribed in Surah Al-Asr (103:3).

Mithaq - Covenant. The trust relationship between the human being and Allah that includes the use of time.

Barakah - Divine blessing. The blessing present in time that is used well, particularly the early morning.

Qiyam al-Layl - Standing in prayer at night. The voluntary night prayer that seizes the most valuable time.

Eid al-Fitr - The celebration marking the end of Ramadan. An annual punctuation in the Islamic calendar.

Eid al-Adha - The celebration during the Hajj, commemorating the sacrifice of Ibrahim.

Siyam - Fasting. The annual season of worship in Ramadan that structures the year.

Zakat - Charity. The annual obligation that connects the use of wealth to the use of time, structuring the year around the communal responsibility.

Hajj - Pilgrimage to Makkah. The annual gathering that structures the year around the physical journey to the House of Allah, performed in the sacred month of Dhul-Hijjah.

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# ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Aira Aurora is an independent researcher and writer specializing in Quranic studies. Her work focuses on close reading of the Quranic text, exploring its themes, narratives, and moral framework with attention to both the original Arabic and the broader human context.

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Her work is published under the pen name Aira Aurora.

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The Quranic treatment of time is a treatment of the human being's most precious and most limited resource. The time that is given is the time that will be accounted for, and the accounting is the reason that the believer must use their time well. The Quranic framework provides the structure, the balance, the perspective, and the program for the use of time, and the person who internalizes this framework lives each day as an investment, each prayer as a renewal, and each moment as an opportunity. The framework is the gift of the Quran, and the gift is available to every believer who approaches the text with an open heart and a willing spirit, seeking to align their use of time with the eternal purpose for which the time was given. The time that is invested well is the time that will pay the eternal dividend, and the dividend is the salvation that Surah Al-Asr promises to those who have faith, do righteous deeds, and counsel each other to truth and patience. The person who has internalized this framework has understood the Quranic view of time, and the understanding is the foundation of a life that is lived with the consciousness of Allah in every moment, from the dawn prayer to the night prayer, from the beginning of the day to the end of the life, and from the worldly time to the eternal time that begins when the worldly time ends. The time that is invested well is the time that produces the eternal dividend, and the dividend is the reward that makes every moment of the worldly life worth the investment. The believer who has learned this lesson has learned the most important lesson that the Quran teaches about time, the most valuable resource, the most limited gift, and the most decisive factor in the eternal destiny of every human being, and the lesson is the foundation of a life that is lived with purpose, with urgency, and with the consciousness of the One who created time and who will ask about every moment of it.